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National Disaster Response Force (NDRF): Battalions, Mandate, and Deployment

DISASTER MANAGEMENT

GENERAL STUDIES

National Disaster Response Force explained for UPSC: DM Act 2005 origin, 16 battalions, training, NDMA hierarchy, domestic operations, and international deployments.



Gaurav Tiwari

UPSC CONTENT TEAM HEAD • WEB DEVELOPER & DESIGNER

PUBLISHED • 18 MAY 2026 •

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Sixteen Five



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The NDRF draws its sixteen battalions from five central armed police forces. Each battalion holds 18 specialised teams of 47 members. Total cadre is approximately 18,000 personnel.

BSF
Border Security
Force

Largest contributor

Patna, Guwahati. Flood response in Ganga and Brahmaputra basins.

8

CRPF
Central Reserve
Police Force

Central reserve

Pune, Greater Noida. Urban flood, search and rescue, CBRN.

4

CISF
Central Industrial
Security Force

Southern coast

Vellore, Arakkonam. Cyclones, coastal flooding.

2

ITBP
Indo-Tibetan
Border Police

High altitude

Ghaziabad, Bhatinda. Mountain rescue, avalanche response.

2

SSB
Sashastra Seema
Bal

Northern arc

Varanasi, Itanagar. UP and the north-east.

2

HQ
New Delhi

ACADEMY
Nagpur · 2014

DG RANK
ADG · IPS

The National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) is the world's largest dedicated disaster response agency and the operational arm of India's disaster management architecture. It was raised in 2006 under the Disaster Management Act 2005 and currently comprises sixteen battalions drawn from five [central armed police forces](#), with personnel trained to respond to natural and man-made disasters across the full spectrum, from earthquakes and floods to chemical, biological, radiological, and nuclear (CBRN) incidents.

The National Disaster Response Force sits beneath the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA), which is chaired by the Prime Minister, and reports operationally through the Director General who is an officer of the rank of Additional Director General of Police. The force has trained almost the entire national disaster management vocabulary into a single uniformed cadre. Every battalion holds the same equipment



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This explainer covers the legal basis for the National Disaster Response Force, its battalion structure and parent forces, the deployment regime in India and abroad, the training infrastructure at the National Institute of Disaster Management and the NDRF Academy at Nagpur, and the UPSC-relevant angles on disaster governance.

Quick Facts on the National Disaster Response Force



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NATIONAL DISASTER RESPONSE FORCE



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Sixteen Five parent forces.

The NDRF draws its sixteen battalions from five central armed police forces. Each battalion holds 18 specialised teams of 47 members. Total cadre is approximately 18,000 personnel.

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SSB
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Varanasi, Itanagar. UP and the north-east.

2

HQ
New Delhi

ACADEMY
Nagpur · 2014

DG RANK
ADG · IPS

BATTALION COMPOSITION

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- **Raised.** 2006 under Section 44 of the Disaster Management Act 2005.
- **Headquarters.** New Delhi.
- **Director General.** Officer of the rank of Additional Director General of Police, drawn from the IPS.
- **Battalions.** 16, drawn from BSF, CRPF, CISF, ITBP, SSB, and Assam Rifles.
- **Battalion strength.** Each battalion has 18 specialised search and rescue teams of 47 members each, approximately 1,149 personnel per battalion.



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- **Reports to Ministry of Home Affairs through NDMA**
- **First inter**  Get the latest UPSC notes and current affairs delivered to you. **ce and**
tsunami).
- **2026 deployments.** Türkiye-Syria earthquake response (Operation Dost), Nepal earthquakes, Myanmar floods, Sri Lanka landslides.

Origin: The Disaster Management Act 2005

The National Disaster Response Force is a creature of the Disaster Management Act 2005. The Act was passed in the aftermath of the [Indian Ocean tsunami of December 2004](#) and the Bhuj earthquake of January 2001, which together exposed the limits of an ad-hoc, state-by-state, ministry-by-ministry response system. Parliament created a three-tier disaster management architecture under the Act.

At the apex, Section 3 sets up the National Disaster Management Authority, chaired by the Prime Minister, with up to nine other members. Below the NDMA, Section 14 sets up the State Disaster Management Authority chaired by the Chief Minister of each state, and Section 25 sets up the District Disaster Management Authority chaired by the District Collector.

Section 44 then authorises the Central Government to constitute “for the purpose of specialist response to a threatening disaster situation or disaster, a force to be known as the National Disaster Response Force.” Section 45 makes the force’s command structure a matter for central government rules. The Disaster Management (NDRF) Rules 2008 set out the establishment, recruitment, and conditions of service.

The force became operational in 2006 with eight battalions. The strength was raised to ten in 2010, twelve in 2018, and sixteen by 2026.

The Sixteen Battalions and Their Parent Forces

Each NDRF battalion is drawn from one of the central armed police forces but functions under NDMA command for disaster operations. The distribution of the sixteen battalions across the parent forces is as follows.



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BSF (8 battalions). The Border Security Force contributes the largest share. BSF battalions are specialised in flood response.



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CRPF (4 battalions). The Central Reserve Police Force battalions are located at Pune, Greater Noida, and other central locations. They handle urban flood, search and rescue, and CBRN response in the western and central zones.

CISF (2 battalions). The Central Industrial Security Force battalions are at Vellore and Arakkonam, covering the southern coastal belt and specialising in cyclone and coastal flooding.

ITBP (2 battalions). The Indo-Tibetan Border Police battalions are at Ghaziabad and Bhatinda, with mountain-warfare specialisation that translates into high-altitude rescue and avalanche response.

SSB (2 battalions). The Sashastra Seema Bal battalions at Varanasi and Itanagar handle north and north-eastern operations.

Some NDMA literature also lists Assam Rifles as a contributing force for north-eastern operations, though the bulk of the sixteen battalions are split across BSF, CRPF, CISF, ITBP, and SSB.

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Geographical Deployment Across India

The sixteen battalions are positioned to give every state a maximum two-hour helicopter response time and a maximum eight-hour road response time. The standard deployment map runs from the north-east at Itanagar and Guwahati, through the Indo-Gangetic plain at Patna, Varanasi, Greater Noida, and Ghaziabad, into the western zone at Bhatinda and Pune, and down the eastern and southern coasts at Bhubaneswar, Arakkonam, and Vellore.

The 4th Battalion at Vellore handles Tamil Nadu, Kerala, and Puducherry, the cyclone- and tsunami-prone south. The 5th Battalion at Pune covers Maharashtra, Goa, and Karnataka. The 6th Battalion at Vadodara covers Gujarat. The 9th Battalion at Patna covers Bihar and Jharkhand, the recurrent monsoon-flood zone. The 10th Battalion at Vijayawada covers Andhra Pradesh and Telangana.



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[the Indian Constitution](#). The 11th Battalion at Varanasi handles Uttar Pradesh. The 7th and 13th Battalions are based in the Western Ghats. The 14th, 15th, and 16th Battalions are based in the Himalayan region. The 17th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 18th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 19th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 20th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 21st Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 22nd Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 23rd Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 24th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 25th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 26th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 27th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 28th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 29th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 30th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 31st Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 32nd Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 33rd Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 34th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 35th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 36th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 37th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 38th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 39th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 40th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 41st Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 42nd Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 43rd Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 44th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 45th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 46th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 47th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 48th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 49th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 50th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 51st Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 52nd Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 53rd Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 54th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 55th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 56th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 57th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 58th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 59th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 60th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 61st Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 62nd Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 63rd Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 64th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 65th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 66th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 67th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 68th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 69th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 70th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 71st Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 72nd Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 73rd Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 74th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 75th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 76th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 77th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 78th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 79th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 80th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 81st Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 82nd Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 83rd Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 84th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 85th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 86th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 87th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 88th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 89th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 90th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 91st Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 92nd Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 93rd Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 94th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 95th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 96th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 97th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region. The 98th Battalion is based in the Eastern Ghats. The 99th Battalion is based in the Western Ghats. The 100th Battalion is based in the Himalayan region.



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Pre-positioning during the monsoon and cyclone season is now an annual feature. The NDRF coordinates with the [India Meteorological Department](#)'s cyclone forecast bulletins and moves teams to landfall coordinates 48 to 72 hours in advance.

Training Architecture: NDRF Academy and NIDM

NDRF DEPLOYMENT • DOMESTIC + INTERNATIONAL

Wheels-up in six hours.

Battalions are pre-positioned across India for two-hour helicopter and eight-hour road response. International missions deploy within 24 hours of a request from the receiving state.

DOMESTIC POSITIONS

Guwahati	1 Bn	Kolkata	2 Bn
Mundali (Cuttack)	3 Bn	Arakkonam · Vellore	4 Bn
Pune (Talegaon)	5 Bn	Vadodara	6 Bn
Bhatinda	7 Bn	Greater Noida	8 Bn
Patna (Bihta)	9 Bn	Vijayawada	10 Bn
Varanasi	11 Bn	Itanagar	12 Bn
Ghaziabad	13 Bn	Reserve · 14, 15, 16	3 Bn

INTERNATIONAL MISSIONS

- Japan · 2011 Tōhoku tsunami
- Nepal · 2015 Gorkha
- Mozambique · 2019 Cyclone Idai
- Nepal · 2023 western quake
- Sri Lanka · 2025 landslides
- Maldives · 2014 water crisis
- Bangladesh · 2017 humanitarian
- Türkiye-Syria · 2023 Op Dost
- Myanmar · 2024 floods

DEPLOYMENT MAP

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Training is centralised at the NDRF Academy at Nagnur, which became fully operational in 2014. The academy trains personnel, state disaster response teams, and countries under the SAARC and BIMSTEC mechanisms, and shares its response from state administrations.



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Specialised modules cover collapsed structure search and rescue (CSSR), medical first response (MFR), CBRN response, deep water diving, mountain rescue, urban flood rescue, and helicopter sling operations. Each battalion is required to complete the INSARAG (International Search and Rescue Advisory Group) certification cycle, and the NDRF was one of the first agencies in Asia to achieve INSARAG Heavy classification.

The National Institute of Disaster Management (NIDM) at New Delhi, established under Section 42 of the DM Act, handles policy training, post-disaster review, capacity building of state administrators, and academic research. The NIDM publishes the National Disaster Management Plan, last revised in 2024, and runs short courses for IAS, IPS, IFS, and state service officers.

Equipment and Response Capability

Each NDRF battalion is equipped with a standardised inventory: collapsed-structure search and rescue tools (concrete cutters, hydraulic spreaders, victim-location cameras), water rescue gear (inflatable boats, life jackets, dewatering pumps), medical first-response kits, CBRN detection and decontamination equipment, and communication assets including INMARSAT terminals and HF radios.

The 47-member team is self-sufficient for 72 hours of independent operation. The team's composition includes structural engineers, doctors and paramedics, electricians, divers, mountain-warfare specialists, communication operators, and dog handlers. Each battalion maintains a kennel of trained search-and-rescue dogs, predominantly Labradors and Belgian Malinois, certified to find live victims under collapsed debris.

The standard response time targets are six hours from alert to wheels-up by air and eight hours from alert to first boots on the ground by surface. Pre-positioned teams during cyclone or monsoon alerts can reach the disaster site in under an hour.



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Domestic Operations: A Selected Record



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operational tempo.

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Kosi floods (2008). First large-scale river deployment, with eight battalions involved in evacuation across Bihar.

Uttarakhand flash floods (2013). Largest helicopter-supported civilian rescue operation in Indian history, with NDRF teams coordinating with the Indian Air Force.

Hudhud cyclone (2014). Pre-positioned response in Visakhapatnam, with seven battalions deployed before landfall.

Chennai floods (2015). Urban flood rescue across the city, with NDRF teams using inflatable boats in flooded residential colonies.

Kerala floods (2018). Largest domestic deployment to date, with all sixteen battalions sending teams or pre-positioning equipment.

Cyclone Fani (2019), Amphan (2020), Yaas (2021), Biparjoy (2023), Michaung (2023). Pre-landfall evacuation and post-landfall search and rescue across eastern and western coastal states.

Sikkim flash flood and Joshimath subsidence (2023). High-altitude mountain rescue and structural evacuation.

Wayanad landslide (2024) and Brahmaputra floods (2025). Combined search-and-rescue and medical first response.

International Deployments and Soft Power



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National Disaster Management State. DISTRICT.

The DM Act 2005 sets up a three-tier institutional architecture with the NDMA at the apex, SDMA at the state level, and DDMA at the district level. The NDRF is the operational force under Section 44.

SECTION 3

NDMA · National Disaster Management Authority

Chaired by the Prime Minister. Up to 9 other members. Frames the National Plan. Issues guidelines.



SECTION 14

SDMA · State Disaster Management Authority

Chaired by the Chief Minister. Frames the State Plan. Coordinates state-level response.



SECTION 25

DDMA · District Disaster Management Authority

Chaired by the District Collector. Implements the District Plan. First responder at scene.

SECTION 44

NDRF

Specialist response force. 16 battalions from CAPF.

SECTION 42

NIDM

National Institute of Disaster Management. Policy and training.

FUNDS

National Disaster Response Fund (Section 46) · National Disaster Mitigation Fund (Section 47) · SDRF and SDMA at state level.

DM ACT HIERARCHY

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The Disaster Management Act 2005 anticipated international response. Section 35(2) lets the Central Government send NDRF abroad on a humanitarian mission with the consent of the receiving state. The first such deployment was to Japan after the 2011 Tohoku earthquake and tsunami.

Subsequent international missions include Nepal (2015 Gorkha earthquake and 2023 western Nepal earthquake), the Maldives (2014 water crisis), Bangladesh (2017 Rohingya humanitarian response), Mozambique (Cyclone Idai 2019), Türkiye and Syria (Operation



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Operation Dost in Türkiye and Syria was the largest single international deployment, with three battalions deployed. The force was deployed from Ankara. The force was deployed by the Indian Ministry of External Affairs.



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NDRF deployments have become a regular element of Indian soft-power projection in the Indian Ocean and South-East Asian region.

Relationship with State Disaster Response Forces

Each state is required to constitute a State Disaster Response Force (SDRF) under Section 44 read with the DM Rules. The SDRFs are trained by the NDRF Academy and follow the same equipment standards and operational protocols, with adaptations for state-specific disaster profiles.

The SDRFs handle the first 24 to 48 hours of any disaster within the state, after which the NDRF takes over the lead role if the scale exceeds state capacity. In recurrent disasters such as Odisha cyclones and Assam floods, the SDRF and NDRF operate as a coordinated force, with the NDRF providing specialist equipment and the SDRF providing local knowledge and faster initial response.

This federalised model has been one of the more successful pieces of cooperative federalism in the Indian public-administration record.

UPSC Angles on the National Disaster Response Force

For prelims, the National Disaster Response Force is tested on the year of constitution, the legal basis (Section 44 of the DM Act 2005), the number of battalions, the parent CAPFs, the rank of the Director General, and the location of the training academy.

For mains GS-III, the disaster management section asks about institutional architecture, the NDMA-SDMA-DDMA hierarchy, the role of the NDRF in cyclone and earthquake response, the comparative position with other countries' disaster forces such as FEMA in the United States or the Japan Self-Defence Forces' disaster brigade, and the ecological context examined in pieces like the [ecological energy pyramid](#). The discussion of



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diplomacy, and is sometimes paired with internal-security force comparisons including the [Indian Air Force](#) and the [Indian Navy](#). For ethics, the [NDRF's role in the 2013 Delhi riots](#) and the Türkiye earthquake of 2023 has been cited as a case study in selfless public service. The chapter on probity in public life draws on the institutional culture the NDRF has built.



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Frequently Asked Questions

What is the National Disaster Response Force?



The National Disaster Response Force is a specialist disaster-response agency of India, constituted under Section 44 of the Disaster Management Act 2005 and operationalised in 2006. It comprises sixteen battalions drawn from central armed police forces and responds to natural and man-made disasters domestically and abroad.

Under which Act was the NDRF raised?



How many battalions does the NDRF have?



Who heads the NDRF?



Where is the NDRF Academy located?



What are the major international deployments of the NDRF?



What is the difference between NDRF and SDRF?



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